CAMERA ROLLING

The next step was finding the right cast. Ishaan Khattar was roped in to play Shoaib, the fictional alter ego of Saiyub, and Vishal Jethwa for Chandan, that of Kumar. For Ghaywan, it was imperative that his leads, both hailing from different backgrounds in Mumbai, underwent an immersion workshop. It sent the actors, Ghaywan, Dubey and some of the production crew to villages in Uttar Pradesh—Harauni, Hassanganj, Unnao, Shekhpura and Barabanki—to familiarise themselves with the emotional and physical worlds of the characters. "It's essential that you have to get close to their lived reality. You have to put in the work, you can't just imagine it," says Ghaywan.

Khattar and Jethwa loved this process of "surrendering" themselves before the film went on floors. The latter spoke of how Ghaywan asked them to "be vulnerable, share their insecurities and past, listen to each other without judgement" to forge the friendship he knew to be the film's emotional spine. The idea is to "try and live it, let it mean something to you", says Khattar. "You don't always get the opportunity to do so [while making a film]." For Chandan's character arc, Ghaywan dug deep into his own life growing up in a patriarchal Dalit household where he was the favoured male child and what his journey was like accepting his caste identity. Another asset to the film was Janhvi Kapoor, who had wanted to work with Ghaywan for a while and didn't charge a fee to play Sudha Bharti, a Dalit woman who firmly believes in Ambedkar's viewpoint that education is liberation from oppression.

With a budget under Rs 20 crore and set around two men surviving on the margins, *Homebound* was as "unDharma" a film can be, says Mishra. Shot predominantly in villages on the outskirts of Bhopal, followed by a schedule in Surat and a few days in Mumbai, it has "no massive sets", says production designer

INDIA'S SUBMISSION AT THE OSCARS

Homebound is up against some heavyweights for the Best International Film prize at the Academy Awards



SENTIMENTAL VALUE (Norway)

Joachim Trier's last film, *Worst Person in the World*, was much beloved by the Academy, scoring two nominations. His latest, a drama about an estranged father reconnecting with his two daughters, won the Grand Prix award at Cannes. It's favoured to bag nominations for best screenplay, best actress and supporting actor too.

IT WAS JUST AN ACCIDENT (France)

The Iranian government has imprisoned director Jafar Panahi repeatedly but he's mastered the art of making sublime films amid censorship. The Cannes Palme d'Or winner is an early frontrunner, with many seeing the Oscar as a way to honour his impressive oeuvre and moxie.





THE VOICE OF HIND RAJAB (Tunisia)

Kaouther Ben Hania's docu-drama about the killing of 5-year-old Palestinian girl Hind Rajab by Israeli forces is likely to resonate with Academy voters.

THE SECRET AGENT (Brazil)

Wagner Moura, winner of best actor at Cannes, leads this thriller set against the backdrop of the final years of the Brazilian military dictatorship.





NO OTHER CHOICE (South Korea)

Having amassed a cult following for films like *Oldboy*, *Lady Vengeance*, *The Handmaiden* and *Decision to Leave*, Park Chan Wook in his latest shows the desperate and depraved side of humanity. This one entails a high body count—as well as laughs.